ing manager, her job was to bump up the revenue in any way she could. The hotel only had a French restaurant, and the Sea Lounge which served tea. Panjabi opened Shamiana, India's first coffee shop there, followed by Golden Dragon, India's first Sichuan restaurant. The rest is culinary history. Panjabi's



impact on the evolution of Indian restaurants is immense—and it continues to shape the very DNA of India's food landscape even today.

Panjabi takes it easy these days—but only a bit. She gets up late, then reads four newspapers, an old habit—"I like to know what people are thinking in general"—before heading to the office. Thrice a week, she visits her restaurants, to get customer feedback first-hand. Asked if she has plans of hanging up her apron anytime soon, she says, unexpectedly, "Yes, I would like to." But not before she's written another cookbook, we think. ■

–Amit Dixit

FOOD ▶

Indian Pizza Rising

TWO **DELHI-BASED PIZZERIAS** EARN GLOBAL RECOGNITION, PUTTING INDIA FIRMLY ON THE INTERNATIONAL PIZZA MAP

India's food landscape is steadily making its mark on the global stage, with pizza being in the spotlight this time. The recently released 50 Top Pizza World 2025 rankings saw Gurugram's Pizzeria da Susy secure a position, adding to its earlier achievement of 71st place among the Top 100 at the Best Pizza Awards 2025 in Milan.

For Susanna "Susy" Di Cosimo, the journey began almost by accident. A native of Naples, she moved to India in 2013 and ran a travel agency for eight years before exploring what she calls the "white art" of baking. Starting with bread, she gradually moved to Neapolitan pizza. "What began as a pastime quickly turned into an obsession," she recalls.

Encouraged by the response, Di Cosimo opened her first Pizzeria da Susy in 2021 in Gurugram. Today, she runs two prime outlets in the city and enjoys recognition worldwide.

Her approach combines long-fermented doughs made from high-quality Italian flour. Classic pizzas like *salsiccia e friarielli* are adapted using Indian mustard leaves, while innovations such as a Palak Paneer–inspired pizza with spinach cream and buffalo ricotta reinterpret Indian flavours through an Italian lens. "I just put out what I believe in," she says. "Some like it, some don't." Her creations have not only won awards but also cultivated a loyal following across India.







HEAVENLY CRUSTS Susanna Di Cosimo and, left, a wood-fired oven at Pizzeria da Susy; below, a pepperoni pizza at Leo's

YASH KALRA

Delhi's Leo's Pizzeria, another contender on the global stage, ranked 99th in the Best Pizza Awards 2025. Founder Amol Kumar started it in December 2016, driven by personal craving rather than business strategy. "I wanted to eat this style of pizza and couldn't find it anywhere," he recalls. To master it, he travelled to Italy.

Over time, Leo's has built a reputation for consistency and restraint. Each dough follows a 48-hour fermentation cycle, combining imported and local ingredients. The pizzeria prioritises Italian techniques, including the preparation of sauce. To cater to local tastes, chicken is added as a topping, otherwise a rare practice in Italy.

Kumar emphasises rigorous training, standardised processes, and careful sourcing to maintain quality. "Global recognition is a massive validation for India's artisanal pizza movement," he says. "We always believed we made pizza of a global standard. To represent India on that stage is an honour." ■

—Geetika Sachdev